Scrum Open Assessment: Reflection Note

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The activity and why I chose it

Goal 4 of my Professional Learning Plan was to demonstrate the ability to select and apply an appropriate project delivery methodology. I rated myself at SFIA level 1 (Follow) against it, because my exposure to methodology had been observational: stand-ups I attended and delivery routines defined by other people, rather than anything I had applied to work I was accountable for.

The Scrum component of that goal needed a starting point that was free, fast and gave real feedback. The Scrum.org Scrum Open assessment met all three. It is thirty questions drawn from a larger pool, it carries no fee, and unlike the paid Professional Scrum certification assessments it returns the correct answer and an explanation for every question. That feedback is why I chose it over simply reading about Scrum: I wanted my assumptions tested rather than confirmed.

It is worth stating plainly that the Open assessment is a free self-assessment tool, not a certification, and Scrum.org notes its questions are less difficult than those in the certification assessments. I am recording it as a diagnostic, not a credential.

What the two attempts showed

I have treated this as a repeat-attempt exercise rather than a single sitting, using the per-question feedback as the learning mechanism. The two attempts recorded here are from 20 October 2026, scoring 70% and then 93.3%.

The most useful single data point sits in the feedback on the first attempt. Asked which Scrum events are timeboxed, I selected some but not all of the correct options. The same question appeared on the second attempt and I answered it correctly. The underlying misconception was that I had been treating the Sprint itself as the timebox and the events inside it as loosely scheduled meetings. The Scrum Guide’s position is that Sprint Planning, the Sprint Review and the Sprint Retrospective each carry their own maximum duration, scaled to Sprint length, while the Daily Scrum is fixed at fifteen minutes regardless of how long the Sprint runs.

That distinction matters more than it first appears. A timebox is a maximum, not a target and not a minimum, which means the discipline is in finishing within it rather than filling it. I had previously read the stand-ups I attended at work as a status ritual of roughly fifteen minutes. They are a fifteen-minute inspection point owned by the people doing the work, which is a different thing.

What I still had wrong at 93.3%

The question I did not fully answer on the second attempt asked which statements about Scrum are incorrect or misleading. Three of the distractors are worth recording, because each is a belief I was carrying:

1. That Scrum can be adopted selectively, keeping the parts that suit the environment. The Guide treats the framework as a whole, with each event serving a defined purpose.
2. That Scrum eliminates complexity. It does not. It provides a way of working with complexity through short cycles of inspection and adaptation.
3. That Scrum replaces project managers with self-managing teams.

The third one is the one I need to sit with, because I am aiming at a project management pathway. My assumption had been that agile delivery displaces the project manager role, which made Scrum feel like a threat to the career direction I have chosen rather than a tool within it. The Guide's position is narrower: Scrum does not define a project manager accountability, and the decision-making that a PM would hold is distributed across the Scrum Team. That is a statement about one framework's internal structure, not a claim that organisations stop needing people who own delivery, budget and stakeholders.

I can now read the Senior IT Project Manager advertisement differently. Its requirement for confidence choosing between Agile, Waterfall and hybrid approaches is asking whether I can judge which structure suits a given piece of work, not whether I can run ceremonies.

Where this leaves the goal

This activity took approximately 1.5 hours against the 10 hours I allocated to the Scrum component of Goal 4. It moves me from no documented Scrum knowledge to a demonstrated grasp of the framework's basics, which is honest progress but is not yet application. Under SFIA I would still rate myself at level 1 for delivery methodology, because knowing the framework and exercising judgement about it are different capabilities.

Two things follow:

- The project plan artefact in my portfolio is where this becomes applied rather than theoretical. Its methodology justification section is the place I have to argue a choice between approaches for a specific project, which is the capability the assessment only tested indirectly.
- The Professional Scrum Master I assessment is the credible next step, and it is substantially harder than the Open assessment. I have not attempted it and would not claim readiness for it on the basis of a free diagnostic.

I am continuing to re-sit the assessment alongside reading the Scrum Guide, and will update this note with later results. The value of the exercise is in the feedback loop rather than any single score: each attempt surfaces a specific misconception, and the explanation corrects it.